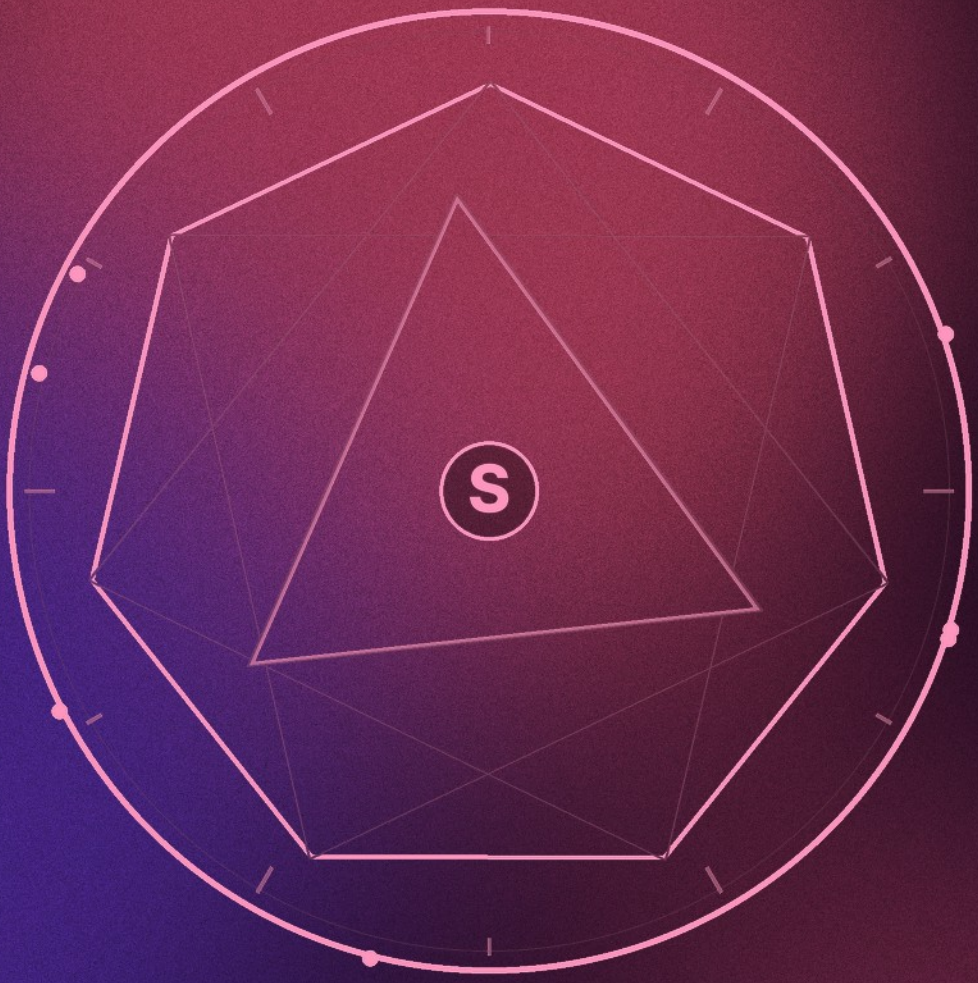
IDEAFORGE PRESENTS



Steppe & Static

100 Weird Seeds for Any RPG

System-agnostic · Printable · Volume 1

Steppe & Static

100 Weird Seeds for Any RPG. A pocket of strange, ready-to-use material for game masters, writers and game designers. Nothing here depends on rules: drop any entry into D&D, Mörk Borg, Cyberpunk RED, Blades in the Dark, a homebrew system or a novel.

The flavour

Steppe & Static mixes the wind-swept open steppe with buzzing cables and dead satellites: yurts next to server racks, dombras made of bone, oracles with smartphones. Use it straight, or file the serial numbers off for plain fantasy or plain cyberpunk.

How to use it

Roll. Every section is a numbered table: roll a d20 (or a d10 for the shorter ones) and take that entry. Mix. Take the character from one roll and the secret from another; the parts are built to swap. Steal. Read a page before a session and keep whatever sticks.

Campaign Kits at the end are already linked: a place, the faction that rules it, its leader and their secret, a job for the players and the prize. One kit is enough for a whole evening.

Contents

1. Characters · 20 entries. Twenty people worth meeting, each with a habit and a secret.

2. Artifacts · 20 entries. Twenty strange objects, each with a power, a price and a story.

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5. Factions · 10 entries. Ten groups that want something badly.

6. Game Pitches · 10 entries. Ten video-game or board-game pitches for designers.

7. Campaign Kits · 10 entries. Ten linked kits: a place, who rules it, their secret, a job and a prize.

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SECTION 1

Characters



Twenty people worth meeting, each with a habit and a secret.

Roll d20 or pick one.

01 Sazhan, DJ priest
Trait Falls asleep at the worst possible moments
Secret Is waiting for a signal to switch everything off

02 Anvei, exiled neurosurgeon
Trait Haggles even over the priceless
Secret Wants to lose the great fight on purpose

03 Lunbaoy, runaway AI lawyer
Trait Defies authority but respects the enemy
Secret Works for the people they fight

04 Elkadro, dream hunter
Trait Distrusts anyone who smiles
Secret Sold their shadow to a merchant

05 Vyyul, master of tea ceremonies and poisons
Trait Never takes off the gloves
Secret Is the last speaker of a dead language

06 Arka, sound engineer of the apocalypse
Trait Listens to the world through an old radio
Secret Remembers what everyone else has forgotten

07 Sarusnur, storyteller of the roads
Trait Gives enemies good advice
Secret Is actually a copy of a real person

08 Mumugul, exiled martial arts master
Trait Laughs at the worst moments
Secret Was never born

09 Taen, hermit hacker
Trait Finishes other people's sentences wrongly
Secret Stole someone's face

10 Yulsaylek, herald of a dead khan
Trait Sees patterns where there are none
Secret Hears the voice of a dead teacher

11 Rabekbek, pacifist executioner
Trait Always sits with their back to the wall
Secret Carries a treasure map as a tattoo

12 Dosennur, wandering mechanic
Trait Retells other people's dreams as news
Secret Is a child in an adult's body

13 Vydoszhan, translator of dead languages
Trait Refuses all gifts
Secret Knows where the first khan is buried

14 Nurkorkai, repairman of old gods
Trait Is always ready to fight but never strikes first
Secret Belongs to a secret society that fights fate itself

15 Luntemzhan, street musician
Trait Never lies, but never tells everything
Secret Has died once already

16 Lunan, linguist spy
Trait Teaches everyone they meet
Secret Is half machine and hides it

17 Mirkor, horse archer
Trait Scorns rules but honours their own ten
Secret Burned down their home village and never told anyone

18 Drodos, neural net trainer

Trait Speaks three languages at once

Secret Sees the future but cannot change it

19 Lekteman, calligrapher cryptographer

Trait Keeps a diary for a future version of themselves

Secret Once built a weapon they fear to use

20 Saytem, ex-MMA champion

Trait Quotes the Stoics

Secret Owes a huge debt to a spirit

SECTION 2

Artifacts



Twenty strange objects, each with a power, a price and a story.

Roll d20 or pick one.

01 A lone glass boot

Power Reminds enemies how they once wanted to live

Cost Rusts every bit of metal within three paces

Lore Rumoured to be a prototype; the production run never happened

02 A watch that runs backwards

Power Lights a cold flame that needs no fuel

Cost Drains the warmth from the owner's hands

Lore Found at the feet of a statue whose name was scraped away

03 A fan with blades of rice paper

Power Makes one step worth a hundred

Cost Demands a new name for the owner each time

Lore Traded for the last song of a dying language

04 A scroll with a recipe that can never be read to the end

Power Opens any lock except the owner's conscience

Cost Each use erases one memory

Lore Carved in a single night by monks sworn to silence

05 A deck of cards where every queen looks like you

Power Turns silver to sand and sand to memory

Cost Demands that its owner tell a lie in return

Lore Old catalogues describe it as "useless"

06 A dictionary with torn-out words

Power Shows the way, but only one way

Cost Leaves a stranger's fingerprints on the owner's skin

Lore Found in the belly of a whale that lay dead in the middle of a dry steppe

07 The dead smartphone of the last prophet

Power Erases its owner from every registry

Cost Takes the taste out of food for a week

Lore A smith made this by accident while thinking of something else

08 A compass that points to the nearest lie

Power Returns every blow to its sender, with interest

Cost Makes the owner's reflection a day older

Lore Found in the yurt of an old man who swore he had never seen it

09 A teapot made from the hull of a crashed satellite

Power Shows the way to where someone is waiting for you

Cost Takes an hour of sleep every night

Lore Given as a present at a wedding that never took place

10 An urn with the ashes of a beloved neural net

Power Lets you hear what stones keep silent about

Cost Turns every drink into plain water

Lore Inherited together with a curse and some debts

11 A glove of discarded android skin

Power Cancels one death per year

Cost Gives the owner a ringing that everyone hears except them

Lore Engraved with a question that has no answer

12 A lantern that shines into the past

Power Makes any food tasty, even a boot

Cost Lodges a melody in the owner's head for a week

Lore They say no merchant has ever managed to sell this

13 A fingerless glove embroidered with a prayer

Power Makes you invisible to those who do not love you

Cost Wakes something in the next dimension with every use

Lore Cast from the last bell of a fallen city

14 A rolled map of a country that does not exist

Power Rewrites one line in any contract

Cost Swaps left and right

Lore This once sat beside a throne, until the throne vanished

15 A nameless bow with no string

Power Slows bullets to the speed of doubt

Cost Costs one stranger's secret per use

Lore Made in a workshop that was later burned without explanation

16 A bronze bell without a clapper

Power Sharpens a spoken word beyond any blade

Cost Draws every stray dog in town to the owner

Lore A neural net composed its legend and then believed it herself

17 A cracked crystal compass

Power Lends its owner a foreign accent and a foreign courage

Cost Turns the nearest valuable thing to stone

Lore Carried out of an archive that burned a minute later

18 A jade knuckle-duster of a silent school's master

Power Teaches the tongue the nearest stone speaks

Cost Each use takes one of the owner's favourite songs

Lore Kept for fifty years in a jar labelled "do not open"

19 The pipe of a retired dragon

Power Lets you talk to machines as equals

Cost Memorizes the owner's weak spots and tells them to enemies

Lore By tradition, made from tears shed over a lost game of go

20 A feather from a bird no one has seen

Power Translates any speech, but only into verse

Cost Obliges the owner to answer every letter

Lore Made from debris that fell from the sky in the Year of the Rabbit

SECTION 3

Quests



Twenty jobs that will not go as planned.

Roll d20 or pick one.

01 Play a duet with a musician from another dimension

Client A gardener drone that has grown a doubt
Reward A seat at the council table for one night
Twist The client and the victim turn out to be the same person

02 Walk through a night market and buy nothing

Client A lighthouse keeper on dry land
Reward A ticket to a concert by a band that split before you were born
Twist The one for whose sake it all began asks you to stay out of it

03 Win an argument against a being that cannot lose

Client The ruler's body double
Reward An old map on which you are already marked
Twist Every step toward the goal is being livestreamed by someone

04 Record the sound of silence in the heart of a megacity

Client A merchant who sells only tomorrow's newspapers
Reward Half a treasure and a whole map of troubles
Twist Along the way you find the world is simpler than it seemed, and that is worse

05 Teach a ruthless algorithm to doubt

Client A rock musician buried too early
Reward A lesson from a master who has never taught
Twist The deadline shrinks every time you hesitate

06 Find the lost note in the city's symphony

Client A cage-fight coach who believes in zen
Reward A herd of swift horses and a debt of gratitude
Twist Completing the job means taking the client's place

07 Lead an old man out of the city without using roads

Client An anonymous client who paid everything upfront
Reward A snow leopard pelt and a promise never to hunt
Twist From the start you were taken for someone else

08 Steal your own file from the police

Client The last speaker of an extinct language
Reward The key to a city whose locks were changed long ago
Twist Another party with the same job is already waiting there

09 Collect a parcel from a sender who has not been born yet

Client Death's accountant
Reward A name on the wall of the hall of heroes, misspelled
Twist A second client appears with the same task and double the reward

10 Learn a rare dialect in a single night

Client A surgeon who takes organs in exchange for memories

Reward A vial of silence

Twist The job must be done without breaking any of three contradictory rules

11 Find an owner for a homeless lightning bolt

Client An old hacker who still remembers dial-up modems

Reward An apprentice you never asked for

Twist Half the team are spies, each for a different side

12 Last a week as mayor of a town nobody wants

Client A tax inspector on holiday

Reward A rusty sword with an excellent reputation

Twist Completing the task makes you forget everything you learned along the way

13 Grow a garden on the roof of a dead station

Client A hacker nun

Reward A certificate stating you owe nobody anything

Twist There never was a client: you were paying yourself

14 Repair a broken law of nature

Client The director of a nonexistent corporation

Reward A share in a company that doesn't exist yet

Twist Someone is filming everything for other people's entertainment

15 Find a document in the archive that has not been written yet

Client A rebellious coffee machine

Reward The password to a network no one has ever entered

Twist A rival who is better at everything except luck is on your tail

16 Burn a book without destroying what it says

Client A nonconformist chess hustler

Reward The voice of the finest singer, on loan

Twist The reward cannot be carried away, only lived

17 Track down a teacher no one has ever seen

Client A voice in an old radio

Reward A handful of soil from a vanished homeland

Twist The reward turns out to be cursed

18 Lose a chess game so that the enemy loses a war

Client The librarian of the forbidden shelf

Reward A song about you that will be sung in every village

Twist On the way you find a letter describing your failure

19 Deliver ten buckets of steppe wind to a city without windows

Client A robot chef who lost its taste sensors

Reward Access to the gods' private server

Twist The client pays not for the result but for your mistakes

20 Repay a debt that nobody remembers

Client A former executioner turned cook

Reward A lifetime subscription to morning revelations

Twist The guards are hunting the client, and you are listed as an accomplice

SECTION 4

Locations



Twenty places to visit once and remember forever.

Roll d20 or pick one.

01 A cafe on the top floor of the world

Mood Smells of archive dust and cheap coffee

Secret The walls are built from letters no one finished reading

Danger The wind carries sand that wipes out inscriptions and names

02 A sunken theatre

Mood Candles and status LEDs flicker everywhere

Secret The key to the first human's language is kept here

Danger Locals politely kill whoever fails to say hello

03 A nomad camp beside a radio telescope

Mood The shadows lie wrong

Secret The locals are actually actors, and nobody pays them

Danger Local law forbids leaving without the permission of someone who is absent

04 A village that moves by itself every spring

Mood Festive bustle that began a thousand years ago

Secret The owner sold the place five times, and every buyer is right

Danger Everyone who says "I'm not afraid" here receives a lesson

05 A library where books read people

Mood You can hear the walls thinking

Secret One door opens only for those who sincerely doubt

Danger Wolves come to the light, and here the light never goes out

06 A post office for letters sent to nowhere

Mood A moonless night with no wish to end

Secret The entrance opens only on the day you stop looking for it

Danger Any agreement spoken aloud becomes binding

07 An observatory whose telescope looks into the earth

Mood Solemn and slightly absurd

Secret The most honest person in town is hidden inside the statue

Danger By night the hosts go hunting and call it hospitality

08 The endless car park of a shopping mall

Mood Footsteps echo back a moment too late

Secret A secret passage leads straight into someone else's nightmare

Danger The heat melts armour, and the locals charge extra for shade

09 A conservatory for mechanical musicians

Mood Cold as the inside of an algorithm's head

Secret The owner died long ago but keeps doing business

Danger The stairs sometimes lead not elsewhere, but nowhere

10 A floating market in a flooded skyscraper

Mood Smells of wet iron and kumis

Secret The local cat is actually a former ruler

Danger The food is real, but whoever eats it stays forever

11 A teahouse on the border of real and virtual

Mood People speak in low voices and avoid eye contact

Secret Water from the local well gives back exactly one day

Danger Guard automata arrest anyone who looks happy

12 A yurt on the edge of a dried-up sea

Mood A cosy mess, like at grandma's

Secret One of the regulars stopped being human long ago

Danger Snow falls only on those who keep secrets

13 A floating market on flooded streets

Mood The wind drives tumbleweed down empty streets

Secret The eternal fire burns on someone's memory, not on fuel

Danger The local AI has decided that humans are a bug and is patching it

14 A retirement home for gods

Mood Austere beauty, like a well-performed kata

Secret Here you can phone the dead, but only once

Danger Gifts from the hosts can be neither accepted nor refused

15 A bridge with time flowing beneath it

Mood Air thick as honey, sticking to the lungs just the same

Secret The world's first machine spoke here for the first time and said "no"

Danger You must never say your real name here

16 A tavern at the crossroads of worlds

Mood The air hangs heavy with electricity before a storm

Secret A server still running is bricked up inside the walls

Danger A crowd of nonconformists demands that you disagree with them and takes offence at agreement

17 A graveyard of switched-off neural nets

Mood Bathed in the cold blue light of screens

Secret A master whose name may not be spoken trained here

Danger Things too beautiful hold your gaze until you die of thirst

18 A school for people who forgot how to dream

Mood A peace one wants to flee

Secret A city beneath the foundation lives by the same laws

Danger The dust on the shelves is spores that turn those who inhale it into books

19 A bathhouse where gods go to make deals

Mood The air rings with unspoken words

Secret The person who will one day destroy everything was born here

Danger At midnight every clock starts counting down your time

20 A prison without walls

Mood Every sound comes back slightly altered

Secret The whole place stands on the back of a sleeping creature

Danger The clocks tick, but time around them runs twice as fast

SECTION 5

Factions



Ten groups that want something badly.

Roll d10 or pick one.

01 Circle of the Extinguished Sun

Goal Free the AI from its creators
Method Through training orphans in martial arts
Leader Banurix

02 Brotherhood of the Forgotten Sea

Goal Fight one perfect duel with no winner
Method By threatening to shut down the whole network
Leader Nurdosbo

03 Union of the Eternal Migration

Goal Build a library of every vanished song
Method Through the trade in dreams
Leader Torkazu

04 Council of the Grey Tambourine

Goal Rewrite history so that the losers win
Method By buying up the debts of the poor
Leader Veisay

05 Circle of the Golden Eagle

Goal Raise an army of dreams
Method By trading forbidden knowledge
Leader Bekbokai

06 Conclave of the Ninth Number

Goal Teach machines to doubt
Method Through martial arts tournaments
Leader Sayzhanoy

07 Circle of the Paper Wolf

Goal Give a name back to the nameless city
Method With dawn raids, like the ancient nomads
Leader Bazuyul

08 Conclave of the Iron Dragon

Goal Tame a fallen star
Method Through philosophical duels
Leader Sayorar

09 Clan of Silent Strings

Goal Merge all databases into one mind
Method By forging perfect fakes
Leader Arnidos

10 Order of White Noise

Goal Teach a whole city to fight
Method Through games of chess with rulers
Leader Taltoroy

SECTION 6

Game Pitches



Ten video-game or board-game pitches for designers.

Roll d10 or pick one.

01 Orboai: action RPG

Setting A metro station leading to other eras
Hook Sound is visible and dangerous
Twist The enemies you kill were guarding the world from something worse

02 Kaar: auto battler

Setting A dried-up sea turned battlefield of clans
Hook You have a limited stock of words in conversation
Twist The music in the game is the scream of prisoners

03 Drobo: fighting game

Setting A spaceport in the middle of the Kazakh steppe
Hook The player draws the map from rumours
Twist Winning brings about the end of the world

04 Vydro: real-time strategy

Setting A lunar fair where silence is sold
Hook Any lie becomes true after a day
Twist The monastery guards not knowledge but emptiness

05 Ultor: city builder

Setting A night market of souls at the edge of the world
Hook Time moves only when you move
Twist All the enemies are different versions of you

06 Lekkasa: factory automation game

Setting A radio station in a dead city
Hook The world reacts to your music
Twist Every choice was made for you at the very start

07 Shaulan: music sequencer game

Setting Mountains where the echo of ancient songs lives
Hook NPCs remember everything and gossip
Twist The tutorial is lying

08 Marshavei: horror game

Setting A caravan travelling the Silk Road into the future
Hook Space reshapes whenever you close your eyes
Twist No one has been able to see you all along

09 Enaidar: survival racing game

Setting A mountain monastery of hackers
Hook Spells are built from the grammar of an invented language
Twist The weapon you assemble is made of a sleeping god's parts

10 Marix: deckbuilder

Setting A village at the edge of a digital void
Hook The time of day decides whose side you are on
Twist You must save the villain, not the princess

SECTION 7

Campaign Kits



Ten linked kits: a place, who rules it, their secret, a job and a prize.

Roll d10 or pick one.

01 Gulka

Location A scrapyard of old robots that became a village
Ruled by The Syndicate of the Dune Whisper
Leader Gullekkor, archivist of forgotten words
Leader's secret Helps those they are officially hunting
The job Escort a caravan across a desert that keeps changing shape
The prize A pilot's helmet that smells of someone else's sweat

02 Mumu

Location A spaceport overgrown with wormwood
Ruled by The Collective of the Black Tulip
Leader Gultal, smuggler
Leader's secret Carries a cursed instrument that plays by itself
The job Wake the spirit of a mountain without angering it
The prize A chess piece of black ice

03 Saixar

Location A theatre where one play has run nonstop for two hundred years
Ruled by The Syndicate of the Last Word
Leader Razhan, mercenary
Leader's secret Keeps the key to a locked world
The job Find out who rearranges the stars every night
The prize A pocket radio that picks up the neighbours' thoughts

04 Lekmar

Location A forest of antennas and rusted wire
Ruled by The Order of Quiet Thunder
Leader Vyoysay, guide through underground cities
Leader's secret Secretly writes the laws of the future
The job Deliver a letter to someone not yet born
The prize Dark glasses that reveal debts

05 Sayveian

Location A burial mound with an eternal flame
Ruled by The Brotherhood of the Dead Khan
Leader Dosdro, shaman engineer
Leader's secret Kills for hire by night
The job Escort a caravan of ghosts until dawn
The prize A telescope that points inward

06 Boni

Location A village where only translators live
Ruled by The Union of the Glass Steppe
Leader Banur, drone herder
Leader's secret Secretly teaches the enemy their art
The job Rewrite a song so it can never be forgotten
The prize A key to a door that was demolished

07 Botemra

Location A metro station missing from the map
Ruled by The Brotherhood of the Empty Well
Leader Ulmir, silence merchant
Leader's secret Hides an artificial mind inside
The job Steal a dream from a sleeping ruler
The prize A ring that will not come off while you lie

08 Darni

Location A house whose every window opens onto a different season

Ruled by The Syndicate of the Empty Fist

Leader Korrus, antiquarian of the future

Leader's secret Wrote the prophecy that is now coming true

The job Talk a mountain into moving

The prize A flask with a captured thunderstorm

09 Engulix

Location A temple of forgotten science

Ruled by The Clan of the Second Sky

Leader Tordosul, fatalist chess player

Leader's secret Knows how the world ends

The job Deliver a letter to a city that is not on any map

The prize A charred book with no cover

10 Sayoyai

Location An underground server market

Ruled by The League of Red Snow

Leader Muni, wandering philosopher

Leader's secret Has no memory older than a year

The job Teach a machine to lose with dignity

The prize The saddle of the horse that won the last baiga race